

Real impact player: In last year's T20 home series against England, Andre Russell delivered with both bat and ball, and ended with the most wickets in the series. His form will be crucial for the West Indies in the World Cup.

GETTY IMAGES

average runs per wicket (27.53), trailing only Australia and India during the same timeframe.

When we compare and contrast these numbers with the stats from the previous two T20 World Cups (between October 17, 2021, and November 13, 2022), a clearer picture emerges. During that period, West Indies had the fourth-worst run rate (7.80) and the third-worst average runs per wicket (22.32). Since the last T20 World Cup, West Indies has played 16 T20Is, won nine, and lost seven. The nine wins include five at home (vs India and England), two in South Africa, and one each in Australia and the USA (vs India).

Teams also need a strong bowling attack to win matches. Since the last T20 World Cup, West Indies has had the worst bowling strike rate (20) and the second-worst bowling economy rate (9.75). West Indies was successful in 2012 and 2016 due to its versatile attack. Samuel Badree was excellent in the PowerPlay and was superbly supported by Sunil Narine (2012) and Suleiman Benn (2016).

Narine retired from international cricket in November 2023, not having played for the West Indies since 2019. However, he continues to play in T20 leagues worldwide, particularly in the Indian Premier League, where he recently scored his first T20 hundred against the Rajasthan Royals. He is also KKR's joint-leading wicket-taker, taking 13 at 6.72 with his off-spin (till 51st Match vs MI). This form led the West Indies' T20I captain, Rovmroan Powell, to admit he had been "whispering in [Narine's] ears" over the previous 12 months, ahead of what will be the West Indies' first home World Cup campaign since the 50-over competition in 2007. But Narine has



stated that 'that door is closed', ruling out the possibility of an international comeback.

However, Andre Russell's return has injected optimism into the West Indies cricket team. After being absent since the 2021 T20 World Cup, he made his return last year in the T20I squad against England for a five-match series at home. Russell's

impact was felt as he excelled with both bat and ball, emerging as the top wicket-taker in the series, particularly effective in the death overs, and scoring at a blistering strike rate of 169.35.

When it comes to selecting World Cup squads, countries are placing greater emphasis on experience than current levels of performance. West